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Using the Rutgers Oral History Archives and Historical Games to Teach Undergraduates Concepts in American Immigration History

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FOR DECADES, SCHOLARS of immigration and ethnic history have recognized the value of using oral history methodology to better understand the individuals and communities they study. I have found in the course of teaching that oral history transcripts in the classroom can be valuable assets that resonate with students of all ability levels, creating a memorable experience while conveying important concepts that we expect our students to understand after participating in any course that covers these topics. There are many helpful resources available to scholars that can be readily incorporated into a course as thematically specific as “American Immigration History” or as broad as “Twentieth-Century American History”; my focus here will be on the plethora of resources that I have found particularly useful—the full-text life-course oral history interviews of the Rutgers Oral History Archives (ROHA).

ROHA is an ongoing oral history program founded in 1994 as an affiliated center of the Rutgers-New Brunswick History Department.¹ ROHA seeks to document the life experiences of Americans through its own oral history interviews and in partnership with individuals and entities within New Jersey carrying out similar work. ROHA makes its collection available for the benefit of scholars, students, and members of the general public across the Garden State and around the world through its digital online archive, which can be accessed by any user in the world, free of charge (oralhistory.rutgers.edu). In 1997, ROHA became one of the first oral history programs to deliver its material to a global audience through the Internet. In the years since, its online digital archive has been recognized as a world-class oral history resource. ROHA has conducted over 1,300 interviews and processed over 700 for public use, all of which are available to educators on its website.

Through its interviews, ROHA documents how the men and women of New Jersey's towns and cities, ethnic communities, and educational centers went on to shape events on the local, state, national, and global scene. Each interview follows the life-course method, documenting a subject from his or her family background to the subject's present-day activities. This is of particular value for those interested in immigration history, as this method generates a wealth of material on various time periods within each oral history session, presenting a nuanced view of how families came to settle in New Jersey; how ethnic, cultural, and religious communities developed here; how businesses, institutions, and organizations were established and operated in the state; the individual accomplishments of the state's citizens; and many other topics of benefit to educators. ROHA has emerged as a notable resource on the Great Depression in New Jersey; the Second World War, the Korean War, Cold War, Vietnam War, and recent conflicts; the Civil Rights and Women's Rights Movements; immigration history; educational history; and the economic, social and cultural history of New Jersey and the United States in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

The majority of end-users who benefit from the ROHA collection are virtual, with over 25,000 annual unique visitors to its website. Of particular value to educators creating lesson plans for undergraduates is that the collection is presented in full text on the website and is serviced by a search engine that allows users to conduct keyword searches. Users access the interviews (in HTML and PDF formats) through "ID cards" that contain a photo of the interviewee, when available, plus metadata regarding the oral history session(s), usage notes, links to related resources such as photo collections or archival material donated by the interviewee, and a brief description of the interviewee's life experiences. The site also features an alphabetical index and browsable subject-based indexes. The subject-based indexes are created on the basis of expressed user demand and staff knowledge of the material present in the collection. For example, the "Military History" and "Women's History" indexes were developed after users expressed a desire to have all interviews relevant to their needs available in one place. These fully searchable online interview indexes make the collection easily accessible to patrons on all skill levels and eliminate many physical and economic barriers to utilizing the collection's holdings.

Because of the open-access nature of ROHA's oral histories, the collection can be easily and quickly adapted for numerous classroom activities in the college or university setting. What follows is one writing-intensive

activity that I have created for the classroom using the strengths of ROHA's holdings to arouse students' interest in immigration narratives. This activity teaches students rudimentary concepts in American immigration history. One of the challenges of delivering writing-intensive history courses to students is implementing group exercises that are both interesting to the students and useful to the instructor in terms of assessing student writing ability and active engagement with the course material. Using excerpts from ROHA's oral history collection, the author has created a group activity that develops the following skills:

- Encourages students to explore the plethora of immigration narratives from ROHA
- Teaches students basic concepts regarding immigration to the United States and the development of ethnic enclaves in the early twentieth century
- Allows students to build teamwork and networking skills in the process of learning about immigration history
- Challenges students to think critically about immigration narratives from the ROHA collection
- Allows students to practice analytical and interpretive skills using immigration narratives from the ROHA collection

To achieve these objectives, I incorporate ROHA oral histories in a simple turn-based game, with three rounds of play, which I call the "European Immigration Game." The turn-based game consists of a two-foot-by-three-foot historical map of the Atlantic Seaboard in the early twentieth century with a grid of one inch squares placed upon it, much like a checkerboard. Two teams of up to six students compete against one another in a team-based game, trying to achieve a common objective, which is to secure their "immigrant's" place—represented by a 1:72 scale figurine—in the United States. Twenty-four of these figurines will be needed to play the game. The instructor is responsible for moderating the game.

Students are provided with individual worksheets on which they will write the actions they take in each round. Each team of students sets up their figurines on opposite corners of the historical map. When I play the game with my students, I usually designate one team as Polish immigrants and the other team as Italian immigrants, but any region from Europe can be used. During the initial round, students are told that they are free to move about the gridded map and establish "ethnic enclaves" anywhere on the Atlantic Seaboard, resembling an open immigration policy prior to

the restrictive immigration laws passed during the early twentieth century. The mechanism for establishing movement for each figurine is a die (i.e., if a player rolls a five, she moves her figurine five spaces). To establish an enclave on the grid square, a player must roll a four or above; if a Polish enclave is established, a "P" would be written on the grid square; if an Italian enclave is established, an "I" would be written on the grid square. All players on one team must go before players on the other team can move. The initial round ends when all players on both teams have completed their moves. Each team tallies the amount of enclaves they have established at the end of the round (each enclave is worth one point); the score is kept by the moderator.

The second round incorporates excerpts from oral history interviews from ROHA from men and women of Polish and Italian background. There is a large body of material that addresses migration from these areas to the United States. Students are required to read about the experiences of actual immigrants during the second round. For example, in Matthew Drag's oral history interview, he recalls the migration of his father from Europe to the United States prior to World War I, describing the Polish ethnic enclave in Putnam, Connecticut, full of cotton mills fueled by Polish immigrant labor. Drag remembered his father "writing every Sunday a letter to Poland."² For experiences of Italian migrants during the early twentieth century, Peter Sarraiocco recalled his mother and father's experiences in Pennsylvania. "My father came to America as a boy of fourteen, by himself, in 1900," Mr. Sarraiocco remembered in his oral history. "He went to Port Richmond in Philadelphia. It's the northeast section of Philadelphia, where there's a little enclave, which still exists, of Italians."³ These are just two examples of the utility of the ROHA collection; there are hundreds more excerpts, which can be culled from the archives, all done easily through the site-wide search engine.

After students have had sufficient time to read the oral history excerpts, they move a new set of figurines placed on opposite sides of the map as they did in the initial round, with one caveat; any enclave established adjacent to another already established enclave is worth two points. This rule is explained to the students as being necessary to represent the fact that ethnic enclaves offer advantages to new immigrants, including access to networks of employment and people who speak a common language. After the second round score is tallied, students are required to answer questions based on the oral history excerpt that was read. "What movements did you make in this round, and why?" and "Based on the oral history excerpts you have

read, what are some of the reasons that ethnic enclaves were appealing to new immigrants?" are examples of the questions I ask the students at the end of the second round.

During the final round, new rules representing immigration restriction are implemented, explained to the students as being necessary to represent the fact that after World War I, immigration to the United States from Europe was curtailed due to the Immigration Restriction Act of 1921 and the Immigration Act of 1924. No new figurines are introduced in this round. Students are required to answer open-ended questions during the final round, including "What are the possible reasons why the United States enacted restrictive immigration policies?" and "How would restrictive immigration policies affect already established ethnic enclaves?" No points can be earned in this round. Now the scores from the previous two rounds are tallied, and the team with the highest score receives extra credit on the final phase of the activity, the research essay.

The research essay is designed so that students can conduct research in the ROHA online archive for themselves. The three-to-five page writing assignment requires students to research two immigration narratives from ROHA, which they can compare and contrast to the stories they encountered during the "European Immigration Game." It is at this point that I introduce another oral history from ROHA's online archive from a different region of the world/different point in the twentieth century: the oral history of Julius Fabos. Fabos immigrated to the United States after being imprisoned and then escaping to Austria during the failed Hungarian Revolution of 1956, eventually making his way to New York City. Fabos stated in his oral history: "When I was in jail I was very thin, but within two weeks I regained my weight. . . . It was a hard ride, and then, of course, we had all arrived in New York City on the evening before New Year's, imagine, and then, we anchored outside of the city. . . . Imagine that evening we arrive and see Manhattan, the son of a farmer."⁴ Students are asked to compare and contrast the Polish/Italian oral history excerpt and the actions they took during the game to Fabos's immigration experience, using the worksheet they completed in class as evidence to support their arguments. To complete the assignment, students are required to explore ROHA's oral history collection to find their own additional immigration narrative, ultimately comparing and contrasting all three.

The way the assignment is constructed gives students the incentive to take notes on the worksheet during the "European Immigration Game," which they will need to complete the research essay. Because students will submit

their research essays individually, they are responsible for their own grades, and the drawbacks of group activities—such as one student shouldering the academic burden, or random absences—are eliminated.

The resources of ROHA provide the glue that holds this activity together. Not only does the “European Immigration Game” pique student interest in immigration history in a tactile way, but it allows a real assessment of student research and writing skills in the process. The ease of use and open-access nature of ROHA’s materials provides students with opportunities to do independent research at the undergraduate level. For the instructor, core concepts and events in American immigration history can be conveyed, and more importantly, assessed in a tangible way. In a time when online learning is supplementing the traditional delivery of course content, activities such as these—which can only be conducted in the classroom and which allow personal interaction with the instructor on a regular basis—have an even greater value. Of the greatest value, of course, is that undergraduate students are actively engaged with a rich archive of primary source material in an enjoyable way.

NOTES

1. While most users access the Rutgers Oral History Archives via its Web address (<http://oralhistory.rutgers.edu>), there are facilities to accommodate local researchers at ROHA’s physical location at 88 College Avenue, New Brunswick, New Jersey.

2. Matthew Drag, oral history interview, December 3, 1999, by Sandra Stewart Holyoak and Joseph Ciccone, 1, Rutgers Oral History Archives. <http://oralhistory.rutgers.edu>.

3. Peter M. Sarraiocco, oral history interview, March 3, 1995, by G. Kurt Piehler and Chris Everly, 2, Rutgers Oral History Archives. <http://oralhistory.rutgers.edu>.

4. Julius Fabos, oral history interview, October 24, 2011, by Nicholas Molnar and Laura Rice, 24, Rutgers Oral History Archives. <http://oralhistory.rutgers.edu>.